

Technical Note: Four Aspects of the Active Unit - Rūpa, Guṇa, Svabhāva, and Dharma

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Scope: This note clarifies four inseparable aspects attributed to every unit (*ikai*) in Madhyasth Darshan: form (*rūpa*), property or relative power (*guṇa*), essential nature (*svabhāva*), and *dharma*. Its immediate question is whether *guṇa* should be understood as a static quality or as operative power, and how it differs from the other three aspects. Process-language is used as an analytical aid, not as a claim that the primary texts adopt a modern school of process philosophy.

1. The question and central thesis

The ordinary English word “property” can suggest a static predicate: an item on a list that describes what a thing is while leaving the thing itself inactive. That suggestion is misleading here. The same primary texts that define *guṇa* describe units as continuously active, identify power with motion, and present effort, motion, and result as inseparable in every activity. Yet replacing the unit with an unbounded stream of events would be equally misleading. The unit remains a definite bearer with configuration, constitution, and continuity.

The four terms also appear to overlap. If *guṇa* is the unit’s power, why is *svabhāva* separately fundamental? If *svabhāva* is essential nature, what further work remains for *dharma*? If all four are dynamic, what distinguishes *rūpa* from the effects of activity?

The central thesis of this note is:

Every ikai is a bounded, active bearer. Rūpa names its determinate configuration; guṇa its relative power in operation; svabhāva the order-specific characteristic conduct through which that power acquires functional significance; and dharma the order-specific innateness the unit bears. These are four co-present aspects of one unit, not four components or successive stages.

All four are grounded in the unit, but they become evident differently. *Rūpa* is relationally encountered, *guṇa* relationally actualised, *svabhāva* relationally disclosed as characteristic conduct, and *dharma* evidenced through the unit’s order-specific continuity and fulfilment. Relation reveals or actualises these aspects; it does not arbitrarily create them.

2. Textual basis and interpretive status

2.1 The unit as an active bearer

Madhyasth Darshan treats a unit as both state and motion. Force (*bal*) is identified on the side of state and power (*śakti*) on the side of motion, while state and motion remain inseparable. Every activity is correspondingly presented as the inseparable presence of effort, motion, and result (*śram-gati-pariṇām*). These are not three chronological moments. They distinguish the active tendency present, its motion, and the determinate condition attained or maintained within one activity (SB, pp. 58-62, 248-252).

One passage relates that triad directly to the four aspects: effort or force is present as *dharma* and *svabhāva*; motion as *svabhāva* and *guṇa*; and result as *rūpa* and immortality (*amaratva*). The crossing of *svabhāva* between effort and motion prevents a one-to-one derivation. Nor does the reference to immortality mean that every current shape is indestructible; it belongs to the account of constitutional completeness. The passage nevertheless rules out a static bundle-of-attributes reading. Form belongs with determinate result, property with power in motion, essential nature with characteristic conduct across effort and motion, and *dharma* with what the unit innately bears (SB, pp. 60-62).

The phrase **bounded, active bearer** is an analytical synthesis of these claims. “Bounded” preserves the unit as one identifiable entity; “active” preserves the inseparability of state and motion; “bearer” preserves the distinction between the unit as *guṇī* and its relative power as *guṇa*.

2.2 Claim-to-source audit

The following audit distinguishes direct textual definitions from the reconstruction developed in this note.

Claim used in the note	Primary-text basis	Status in this note
Every unit is described through <i>rūpa</i> , <i>guṇa</i> , <i>svabhāva</i> , and <i>dharma</i>	MVD, p. 47	Direct textual classification
<i>Rūpa</i> includes shape, volume, density, boundary-framework, and reflected image	MVD, pp. 42, 50-51; SB, pp. 249-250	Direct textual description
<i>Guṇa</i> is relative power and the effect evident when entities come together	MVD, p. 47; SB, pp. 248-252, 256-257	Direct textual definition and analysis
<i>Sam</i> , <i>viṣam</i> , and <i>madhyastha</i> name generative, degenerative, and mediative directions of power	MVD, pp. 26, 50-51	Direct textual classification

Claim used in the note	Primary-text basis	Status in this note
<i>Svabhāva</i> is essentiality and the usefulness of properties, expressed as conduct	MVD, pp. 47, 77	Direct textual definition and description
<i>Dharma</i> is <i>dhāraṇā</i> , the innateness borne according to order	MVD, pp. 47, 50-51, 115; SB, pp. 179-180	Direct textual definition and order-wise classification
The four are co-present aspects rather than chronological stages	SB, pp. 58-62, read with the four-aspect mapping	Interpretive conclusion
The aspects are unit-grounded but differently encountered, actualised, disclosed, and evidenced in relation	MVD, p. 47; SB, pp. 248-252	Analytical distinction
The four questions can be asked again of a containing compound	MVD, p. 42; SB, pp. 75-76, 260	Analytical reconstruction from the distinction between retained and new conduct

3. Four distinctions within one active unit

3.1 *Rūpa*: determinate configuration

Rūpa names the configuration by which the unit is one definite unit: shape, volume, density, and the boundary-framework associated with its constitution and motion-path. It is not an “absolute effect” opposed to the relative effect of *guṇa*. Form and effect answer different questions. Form answers what configuration is present; property answers how the unit’s power operates (MVD, pp. 42, 50-51; SB, pp. 249-250).

Form is real without being eternally fixed. A developing atom can change in form as its constitution changes. A compound can form and disintegrate. The persistence of a unit therefore does not require one immutable visible shape, but it does require determinacy: there must be some bounded configuration through which this unit is distinguished from another.

Form is also relationally encountered. A unit’s form may be reflected or imaged to another unit, and dimensions are measured comparatively. Reflection does not create the form. It is the manner in which an already configured unit becomes present across mutuality. *Rūpa* is therefore objectively unit-grounded and relationally encountered.

3.2 *Guṇa*: relative power in operation

The primary definition calls *guṇa* relative power (*sāpekṣa śakti*) and associates it with the effect evident when more than one entity comes together. The force-bearing unit is *guṇī* and its operative power is *guṇa*. Bearer and power are inseparable, but they are not identical de-

scriptions: one names the unit, the other what its motion can do in mutuality (MVD, p. 47; SB, pp. 248-252, 256-257).

This is the correct sense in which *guṇa* is process-like. It is not a process floating free of a bearer, and it is not merely a static label. It is a unit-grounded power whose definite influence becomes actual in relation. A unit can possess a power without every possible effect being presently expressed; the actual effect depends on the other unit, distance, configuration, and the mutuality in which they meet.

The three modes describe the direction of that operation:

Mode	Textual orientation	Direction of effect
<i>Sam</i>	Power assisting <i>śṛjan</i>	Generative, formative, or developmental
<i>Viṣam</i>	Power assisting <i>visarjan</i>	Degenerative, dissolutive, or declining
<i>Madhyastha</i>	Power assisting <i>vibhava</i>	Mediative, sustaining, balancing, or conserving

“Regenerative” is too narrow as a general translation of *sam*, because *śṛjan* need not restore a former state. “Generative” is safer. *Madhyastha* does not mean inactivity or an average between extremes. It is active regulation through which generative and degenerative movements remain balanced and a definite organisation is sustained (MVD, pp. 26, 50-51).

These modes are not moral categories. Formation and dissolution both participate in material and biological cycles. The triad identifies directional efficacy before the order-specific significance of that efficacy has been determined.

3.3 *Svabhāva*: order-specific characteristic conduct

The primary definition places two formulations together: essentiality or fundamental character (*maulikata*) is *svabhāva*, and the usefulness (*upayogitā*) of properties is *svabhāva* (MVD, p. 47). “Usefulness” here cannot mean whatever pleases a human observer, nor can it mean moral benefit, because the order-wise account includes devitalising, cruel, and inhumane conduct. It is better understood as **functional significance**: what the unit’s powers amount to as characteristic conduct within its order.

This gives *svabhāva* a purposive direction without imposing an external designer or observer-selected purpose. The direction is internal to the order and the unit’s participation in definite conduct. A power has an effect; *svabhāva* identifies the characteristic kind of conduct expressed through that effect.

Svabhāva is therefore not merely a second classification of *guṇa*. The generic modes *sam-viṣam-madhyastha* recur across the orders, while the classifications of essential nature change with the order. Material essential nature concerns integration and disintegration; pranic essential nature vitalising and devitalising conduct; animal essential nature cruel and uncruel conduct; and knowledge-order essential nature the humane conducts of fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace, and compassion (MVD, pp. 50-51, 58; SB, p. 180).

At the material level the distinction can appear thin because generative and degenerative power closely track integration and disintegration. It becomes clearer in higher orders. A generative effect alone does not tell whether a biological composition nourishes or debilitates, whether animal conduct causes or avoids suffering, or whether human conduct manifests humane or inhumane essential nature. Those are order-specific determinations of what the operation means as conduct.

The texts identify conduct as the activity through which essentiality is expressed and also identify conduct with *svabhāva* (MVD, p. 77). Essential nature is thus unit-grounded as fundamental character but disclosed in definite conduct. Recognition does not invent it; relation is where it becomes evident.

3.4 *Dharma*: order-specific innateness

The definition *dhāraṇā hi dharma* presents *dharma* as what is innately borne or maintained. In this technical use it does not initially mean a religious affiliation, statutory command, or externally imposed moral duty. Nor is it merely the long-term effect of *guṇa*. It names the innateness of the unit according to its order (MVD, p. 47; SB, pp. 60-61).

The order-wise *dharmanas* are cumulative:

Order	<i>Dharma</i> borne by the unit
Material	Existence
Pranic	Existence and growth
Animal	Existence, growth, and hope to live
Knowledge or human	Existence, growth, hope to live, and happiness

A higher order does not lose what is borne in the lower. A pranic unit remains existent while evidencing growth; an animal joint form evidences both and additionally the hope to live; the knowledge order bears the further requirement and possibility of happiness. The table must be read with the body and *jeevan* distinction: existence and growth are evident in the body, whereas hope to live belongs to *jeevan*; in the human, happiness must be realised in *jeevan* for knowledge-order *dharma* to be fulfilled (MVD, pp. 50-51, 115; SB, pp. 179-180).

Conduct can accord with this innateness or fail to evidence it fully. In the knowledge order, happiness is the further *dharma* and resolution is its evidence in understanding and conduct. That human evaluative use should not be projected backwards as a second generic definition of *dharma* for all units.

4. How the four aspects relate

The four aspects answer irreducible questions about one active bearer. The distinctions can be stated once in a common frame:

Aspect	Basic meaning	Dynamic role	Relational status	Not to be confused with
<i>Rūpa</i>	Determinate configuration	Present bounded state or result	Relationally encountered	An absolute, immutable effect
<i>Guṇa</i>	Relative power	Operation and influence	Relationally actualised	A static descriptive quality
<i>Svabhāva</i>	Order-specific characteristic conduct	Functional character of operation	Disclosed through conduct	A mere list of powers
<i>Dharma</i>	Order-specific innateness	What the unit bears	Evidenced in continuity and fulfilment	A temporary outcome or external duty

This is not a causal ladder. *Dharma* does not first produce *svabhāva*, which then produces *guṇa*, which finally produces *rūpa*. The effort-motion-result mapping shows overlap and simultaneity: *svabhāva* crosses effort and motion, and the other aspects qualify the same on-going unit from different standpoints.

Nor is the distinction one between intrinsic and relational aspects in a simple binary sense. All four belong to the unit. Their manifestations differ. Form can be present without being reflected to this observer; power can be borne without every possible effect being actual; characteristic conduct requires a definite situation in which it is displayed; innateness is evidenced through continuity and fulfilment. Relational manifestation does not entail relational construction.

5. Worked examples across the four orders

The order-wise cases test whether the distinction remains intelligible outside a purely abstract definition. They are illustrations of the framework, not claims that the cited texts provide these exact four-paragraph analyses.

5.1 A material compound

A material compound treated as one bounded unit has a determinate shape, volume, density, constitution, and boundary: this is its *rūpa*. Its powers operate in definite mutualities, producing generative, degenerative, or mediative effects: this is its *guṇa*. The integration, disintegration, or continuity displayed through those operations is its material-order *svabhāva*. Its *dharma* is existence.

The example shows why the four cannot be collapsed. The same compound may participate in different effects without acquiring a new essential nature on each occasion. Its present

shape is not identical with any one effect, while the fact that it exists is not a summary of its present integration or disintegration.

5.2 A pranic unit

A plant or living cell has a bounded pranic configuration as *rūpa*. Its active powers participate in formation, decline, and regulation as *guṇa*. The order-specific significance of those powers appears as vitalising or devitalising conduct, its *svabhāva*. It bears existence and growth as *dharma*.

“Useful” in this case does not mean useful to a gardener or observer. It asks what the operation amounts to within pranic order: whether it nourishes and sustains vital organisation or contributes to its debilitation. The same generic power-mode therefore does not exhaust the order-specific description.

5.3 An animal joint form

An animal is a joint form of body and *jeevan*, not merely a more complicated material compound. Its bodily configuration supplies the visible *rūpa* of the joint form. Its operative capacities in sensing, selection, movement, and interaction are expressions of *guṇa*. Their animal-order character appears as cruel or uncruel conduct, *svabhāva*. The animal bears existence and growth through the body and hope to live through *jeevan* as *dharma*.

This example also shows why evaluation cannot be reduced to causal effect. An action can be causally effective while its characteristic significance differs as opposition, protection, cruelty, or non-cruelty. *Guṇa* concerns efficacy; *svabhāva* concerns what kind of animal conduct that efficacy expresses.

5.4 A human in relationship

A human being is likewise a body-*jeevan* joint form with determinate bodily *rūpa*. Power is evident through speech, bodily action, imagination, selection, and influence in relationship as *guṇa*. The character of that conduct discloses humane or inhumane *svabhāva*. The human bears existence, growth, hope to live, and happiness as *dharma*.

Relationship makes the distinctions especially clear. Effective influence alone does not establish right conduct: manipulation can have powerful effects. Humane *svabhāva* concerns the character expressed through the operation, while happiness and resolution evidence the fulfilment of knowledge-order *dharma*. Usefulness is therefore not whatever sustains an existing relationship. It is order-specific functional significance under the requirements of humane conduct and mutual fulfilment.

6. Constituents and containing units

Composition raises a boundary question: when several units meet, do they remain interacting units, or does a further bounded bearer appear? *Guṇa*-effect alone does not answer this

question. Collision, proximity, and mixture can produce definite mutual effects without forming a new unit.

Mixture (*mishran*) and compound (*yaugik*) are distinguished by conduct. In a mixture the participating units retain their respective public conducts. In a compound they combine in definite proportion and exhibit a new kind of conduct as a whole (MVD, p. 42). The constituents nevertheless remain of their order; a further composition does not convert them into a different basic entity (SB, p. 260). Composition must also be distinguished from atomic development toward constitutional completeness (SB, pp. 75-76).

The four questions can therefore be asked at two levels when a further bounded unit is established. Each constituent retains its own configuration, powers, essential nature, and order-specific innateness. The containing compound has a further bounded configuration, a public efficacy as one whole, a characteristic new conduct, and the innateness of that organisation. Calling these “two tetrads” is an analytical convenience, not terminology used by the primary texts.

This reconstruction should not be extended mechanically. A biological body is a further pranic organisation, but animal and human sentience belongs to *jeevan* joined with the body, not to a sum of cells. A family or social assembly is not a physicochemical compound merely because it has continuity and organisation. The unresolved criterion is what degree of boundary, definite proportion, and new public conduct is sufficient to establish a further unit rather than an organised relationship among units.

7. In what sense the interpretation is process-compatible

The four-aspect account is process-compatible if “process” means persistent organised activity. It is not process-compatible if process means a momentary event without a bearer or if every aspect is reduced to current external relations.

First, the unit remains identifiable while active. Configuration, constitution, and boundary prevent activity from becoming an unowned flow. Second, the aspects are co-present rather than chronological stages. Effort, motion, and result are joint aspects of activity, and the four ontological terms cross that triad rather than forming a sequence. Third, relational manifestation must not be confused with observer-construction. Relation is where form is encountered, power actualised, essential nature disclosed, and *dharma* evidenced; it does not invent the unit. Fourth, process-language must preserve the distinction between bearer and power. *Guṇī* is not dissolved into *guṇa*.

A mathematical state-dynamic reconstruction can explore these commitments, but it is not required to define the terms. Treating *rūpa* as a state variable, *dharma* as a potential, and *guṇa-svabhāva* as a family of motion maps adds assumptions about state spaces, potentials, and laws of change that the primary definitions do not supply. Those proposals belong in a formal study where their explanatory value and limits can be assessed independently (*A State-Dynamic Model of Coexistence*, §§2-5).

The more modest conclusion is sufficient here: *guṇa* should be read dynamically as relative power in operation, while the unit should be understood as an activity-whole rather than as nothing but a process.

8. Limits and open questions

8.1 One conduct or a range of conducts

The order-wise lists do not by themselves decide whether *svabhāva* names one conduct presently expressed, a stable disposition, or a structured range of possible characteristic conducts. The distinction matters most in the animal and knowledge orders, where opposite or developmental expressions are described. The safe claim is that *svabhāva* identifies order-specific characteristic conduct; a complete modal theory of which conducts are possible in which states remains to be developed.

8.2 The boundary of a containing unit

The mixture-compound distinction establishes that new public conduct matters, but it does not yet provide a general criterion covering molecule, cell, organism, body-*jeevan* joint form, family, and society. “Two tetrads” should remain a proposed diagnostic: ask whether a new bounded bearer exists before assigning the four aspects at the containing level.

8.3 Two uses of *dharma*

Unit-*dharma* names *dhāraṇā*, the innateness borne in every order. In human analysis, *dharma-adharma* also names an evaluative perspective in thought, and resolved thought evidences human *dharma* as happiness. These uses are related but not interchangeable. The first is ontological and order-wide; the second appears where the knowledge-order unit has option and must understand orderliness. A fuller account belongs with the theory of *nyāya*, *dharma*, and *satya*, rather than inside the definition of the four aspects (MVD, pp. 67, 137, 174; JV, p. 120).

8.4 The limits of formalisation

No equation follows directly from the four definitions. A formal model must specify what counts as state, neighbourhood, power, characteristic conduct, and order-specific continuity, and must show that the model does not treat *dharma* as a global physical potential or *svabhāva* as a superposition of every possible conduct. Formalisation is valuable only if these added commitments remain visible as reconstruction.

8.5 Textual questions

The primary-text passages used here support the principal distinctions, but several interpretive questions remain. The sense of “usefulness” needs comparison across Hindi editions and

translations; the relation between essentiality and conduct requires closer comparison of MVD p. 47 and p. 77; and the effort-motion-result mapping should be checked against the full context of constitutional completeness. These are priorities for a subsequent source-language audit.

9. Conclusion

The four aspects do not describe four layers added to a passive thing. They distinguish four questions about one bounded active bearer. *Rūpa* is the unit as configured; *guṇa* is its relative power in operation; *svabhāva* is the order-specific character and functional significance of that operation; and *dharma* is the innateness the unit bears. Form is not an absolute effect, property is not a static quality, essential nature is not merely a classification of property, and *dharma* is not a temporary result or externally assigned purpose.

This formulation permits a process-oriented understanding without dissolving the unit:

A unit is a bounded activity-whole whose configuration is rūpa, whose relative causal efficacy is guṇa, whose characteristic order-specific conduct is svabhāva, and whose order-specific innateness is dharma.

Editorial Notes

Translation of *guṇa*

“Property” is retained because it is familiar in the existing English translations, but “relative power” is the governing analytical sense. “Quality” should not be read as an inert predicate.

Translation of *svabhāva*

“Essential nature” is retained, while “usefulness of properties” is rendered analytically as functional significance. This does not assert utility to an observer, moral goodness, or an externally imposed purpose.

Analytical vocabulary

“Bounded, active bearer,” “unit-grounded,” “relationally actualised,” and “two tetrads” are reconstructions used to organise textual claims. They are not presented as translations of primary-text terms.

Material removed from the core argument

The earlier version developed a mathematical process-picture using a state variable, an order-typed potential, and a family of motion maps. It also extended the model into a theory of *nyāya*, *dharma*, and *satya* as universal truths followed by default in *jada* and through un-

derstanding in the human. Both extensions introduce independent claims and have been removed from the core exposition. The formal questions are routed to *A State-Dynamic Model of Coexistence*; the universal-truth thesis remains an open subject for a separate technical note.

References

Madhyasth Darshan primary texts

- **MVD** - Nagraj, A. [*Madhyasth Darshan - Co-existentialism*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: mediative regulation (p. 26; §3.2); atomic constitution, mixture, and compound (p. 42; §§2.2, 3.1, 6); definitions of the four aspects (p. 47; §§2.2, 3); form and the *sam-viṣam-madhyastha* distinction (pp. 50-51; §§2.2, 3.1-3.4); inhumane essential nature (p. 58; §3.3); humane and inhumane perspectives (p. 67; §8.3); conduct as expression of essentiality (p. 77; §§2.2, 3.3, 8.5); order-specific *dharma* (p. 115; §§2.2, 3.4); behaviour, thought, and realisation (p. 137; §8.3); the sequence from knowledge through law to justice, *dharma*, and truth (p. 174; §8.3).
- **SB** - Nagraj, A. [*Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad \(Resolution Centred Materialism\)*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: effort-motion-result and state-motion (pp. 58-62; §§2.1, 3.4, 4, 7, 8.5); composition is not development (pp. 75-76; §§2.2, 6); order-specific *dharma* and the body-*jeevan* distinction (pp. 179-180; §§2.2, 3.3-3.4); force, power, form, reflection, influence, recognition, and evaluation (pp. 248-252; §§2.1-2.2, 3.1-3.2); bearer and property (pp. 256-257; §§2.2, 3.2); order of constituents in a composition (p. 260; §§2.2, 6).
- **JV** - Nagraj, A. [*Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: peepal-tree illustration of the four aspects and definite conduct in the first three orders (p. 113; §5); justice on the basis of relationships, *dharma* on the basis of orderliness, and truth on the basis of existence (p. 120; §8.3).

Related studies

- [*The Ontology of Coexistence*](#), especially §1.3 on definite insentient mutuality and §1.10 on composition and assemblies.
- [*From Unit Activity to Human Orderliness*](#), especially §§2–5 on effort–motion–result, the four aspects, and compositional closure, and §8.3 and §11.1 on evaluation and justice as mutual satisfaction.
- [*The Epistemology of Coexistence*](#), especially §1.4 on the six perspectives and on *niyam-niyantran-santulan* with *nyāya-dharma-satya*.